

EXCLUSIVE

‘What is the point of a job when you don’t have a country?’

INDIA TODAY TV’S **GAURAV C. SAWANT** IS IN KYIV COVERING THE CONFLICT. HIS ON-THE-SPOT REPORT

Commander Igor scans the skies as another air raid siren goes off in Ukraine's capital Kyiv. The Russians have systematically targeted Ukraine’s airfields and air defence assets. Igor’s unit has been tasked to defend the main axis to Kyiv from the east.

Young soldiers use earth movers and diggers to dig trenches and build fortifications. Civilians, including women, rush to help, bringing food, water and even manning barricades and roadblocks, checking for suspicious activity or subversive elements. “Russian special forces and Chechen fighters are coming to assassinate President (Volodymyr) Zelensky... we have to stop the enemy at the gates,” he tells INDIA TODAY.

For the defence of Kyiv, multiple levels of security are in place. The army with its tanks and armoured personnel carriers backed by troops with anti-tank guided missiles and surface-to-air missiles man the roads. The second line of defence are local militias with assault rifles.

“We are waiting for Carl Gustaf systems, Javelin anti-tank guided missiles (ATGMs) and Stinger missiles. We have the will power, we need the weapons,” says Misha Michael, a militia commander. Misha is an IT professional but gave up his job to defend Kyiv. “What is the point of a job when you don’t have a country? We cannot let Russia take over Ukraine,” he says.

There is no lack of will but the acute shortage of weapons, including ATGMs and SAMs, will affect Ukraine’s fightback against Russia. “I am willing to join the fight. This is a fight for freedom,” says Oksana, a mother of two in Kyiv. Oksana is also preparing her children, including a pre-teen daughter, for the war ahead.

It’s barely 10 days since Kyiv saw its first air raid (February 24) and the capital already resembles a ghost city. A long week of air raid sirens and missile strikes has resulted in a mass exodus of people from the once bustling capital of Ukraine.

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The situation is even more grim in Kharkiv, the second largest city of Ukraine, barely 30 km from the Russian border. Intense shelling has reduced pockets of the city to rubble. “Kharkiv was a rude shock for the Russian army. They must have thought they would get a rousing reception when they came into Kharkiv. But there was fierce resistance and they were repeatedly pushed back,” says Olexander Turkin, a popular blogger.

The Kharkiv city centre, with its blue and yellow recruitment